WORLD WAR I

SINKING OF SMS EMDEN



Date November 9, 1914
Forces Australians: 1 light cruiser; Germans: 1 light cruiser
Losses Australians: none; Germans: 1 light cruiser

Location Cocos Islands, Indian Ocean

The light cruiser *Emden*, commanded by Karl von Müller, was one of Germany's most successful commerce raiders, paralyzing trade in the Indian Ocean and destroying oil tanks at Madras. Müller earned a reputation for the chivalrous treatment of the passengers and crews of ships he sank. *Emden* evaded or defeated all her pursuers for three months until she met the Australian light cruiser *Sydney*, whose 6-in guns had a greater range than *Emden*'s. Captain John Glossop was able to bombard the ship almost with impunity. Müller beached the battered *Emden* on an island to avoid sinking and reluctantly ran up the white flag.

WORLD WAR I

CORONEL



Date November 1, 1914
Forces Germans: 2 armored cruisers, 3 light cruisers; British: 2 armored cruisers, 1 light cruiser, 1 armed liner
Losses Germans: none; British: 2 armored cruisers

Location Off Coronel, Chile

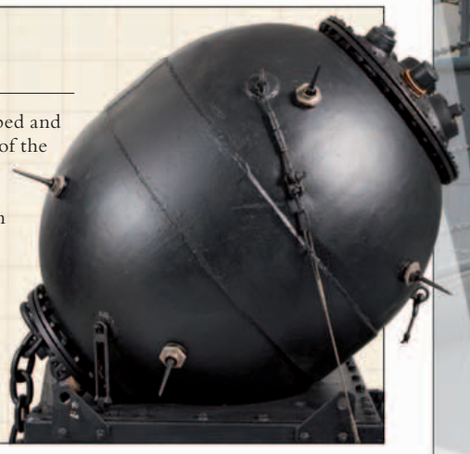
From the start of the war Vice-Admiral Graf Maximilian von Spee was at large in the Pacific with a powerful squadron that included two impressive armored cruisers, *Scharnhorst* and *Gneisenau*. Rear Admiral Sir Christopher Cradock, based in the Falklands, was tasked with seeking out and destroying Spee's squadron, despite having far inferior ships and crews. His armored cruisers *Good Hope* and *Monmouth* were slower than their German equivalents, had obsolescent guns, and were crewed by recalled reservists and half-trained boys. His light cruiser *Glasgow* was at least a fully modern ship, but his armed liner *Otranto* was effectively useless.

The German and British squadrons met in heavy seas off the coast of Chile in the late afternoon of November 1. Steaming to the east of the British, Spee exploited the superior speed of his ships to stay out of range until the sun had set. With Cradock's ships silhouetted against the afterglow, the German ships opened an accurate fire to which the British were barely able to reply. *Good Hope* and *Monmouth*, battered by salvo after salvo in the gathering darkness, sank with all hands, including Cradock. *Otranto* had been sent away at the start of the battle and the badly damaged *Glasgow* escaped into the night. It was a humiliating defeat that the Royal Navy was determined to avenge.

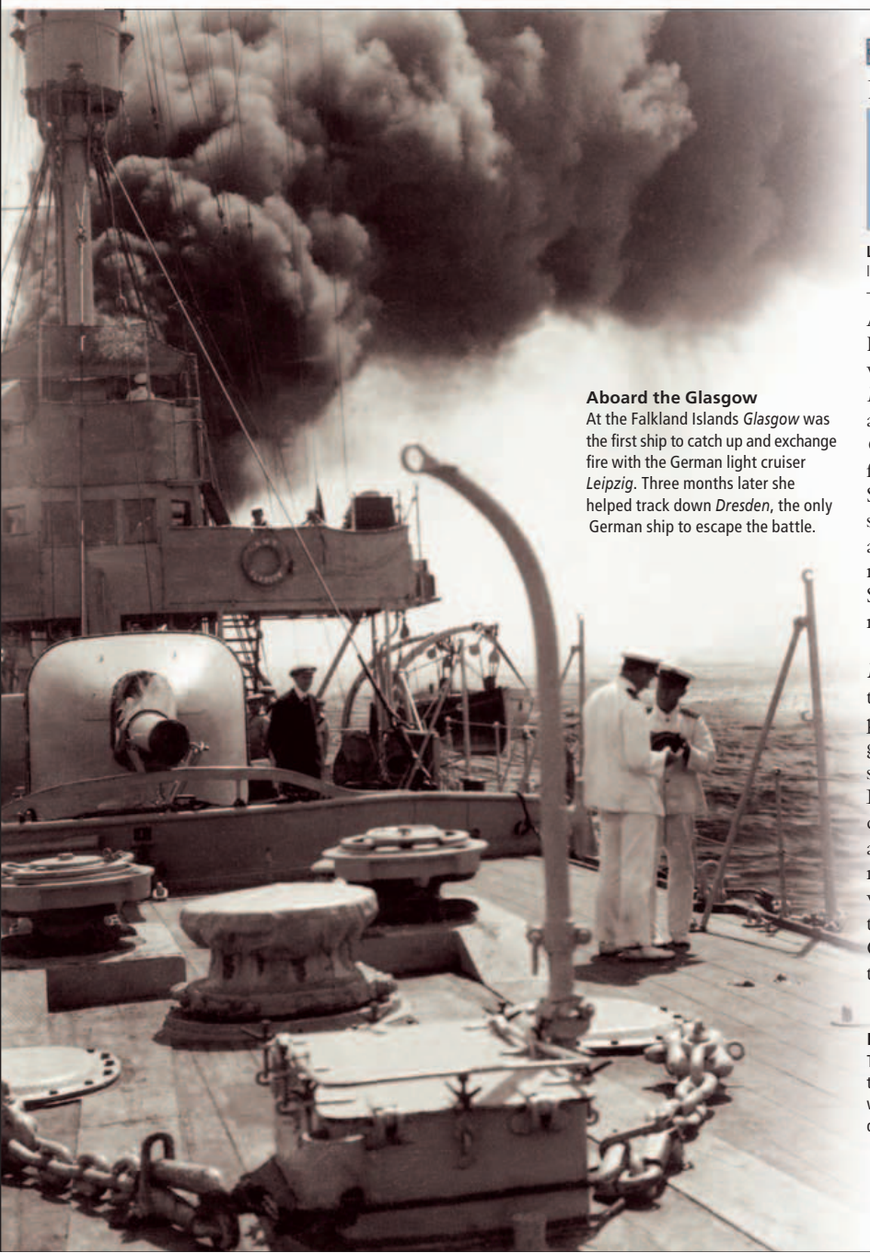
WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

SEA MINES

Contact mines were chained to the seabed and exploded when a ship's hull struck one of the protruding spikes. They were used to great effect by Germany, sinking a greater tonnage of British warships than any other weapon. The Royal Navy entered the war without minelayers or purpose-built minesweepers and did not use mines effectively until 1917.



Contact mine
The length of chain was adjusted so that the mine floated at the desired depth below the surface.



Aboard the Glasgow
At the Falkland Islands *Glasgow* was the first ship to catch up and exchange fire with the German light cruiser *Leipzig*. Three months later she helped track down *Dresden*, the only German ship to escape the battle.

WORLD WAR I

FALKLAND ISLANDS



Date December 8, 1914
Forces British: 2 battlecruisers, 3 armored cruisers, 2 light cruisers, 1 pre-dreadnought battleship; Germans: 2 armored cruisers, 3 light cruisers
Losses British: none: Germans: 2 armored cruisers, 2 light cruisers

Location Falkland Islands, South Atlantic

After the defeat at Coronel, Vice Admiral Frederick Sturdee was sent from Britain with two battlecruisers, *Invincible* and *Inflexible*, to destroy Spee's victorious armored cruisers *Scharnhorst* and *Gneisenau*. Sturdee joined up with the five cruisers of Rear-Admiral Archibald Stoddart's South Atlantic Squadron and steamed to the Falkland Islands, arriving at Port Stanley on December 7. The next day, unaware of the British ships, Spee's squadron appeared, having rounded Cape Horn from the Pacific.

As *Gneisenau* and the light cruiser *Nürnberg* approached Port Stanley they were fired on by the antiquated pre-dreadnought battleship *Canopus*, grounded at the harbor mouth as a shore battery. The British warships, caught in harbor and some in the middle of coaling, were vulnerable to attack, but the Germans fled at the sight of the unexpected battlecruisers. The British had time to get up steam and set to sea in pursuit. Spee realized he had no chance of outrunning the battlecruisers. He decided to engage them with *Scharnhorst* and *Gneisenau*, hoping to buy time for the light cruisers at least to escape.

THE SQUADRON DESTROYED

The German admiral fought a cunning delaying action against an enemy with superior guns and armor, but the end was inevitable. On fire and listing heavily, Spee's flagship *Scharnhorst* sank with her admiral and all hands just after 4:00 p.m. *Gneisenau* lasted longer. She went down at around 6:00 p.m. after taking more than 50 hits. Some 200 of her crew were rescued from the icy waters. The light cruisers *Nürnberg* and *Leipzig* were pursued, engaged, and sunk by the armored cruisers *Kent* and *Cornwall* and the light cruiser *Glasgow*. The only German ship to escape was the light cruiser *Dresden*, but she too was eventually hunted down. It was a crushing British victory, achieved by the application of overwhelming force.



HMS Canopus
The opening shots at the Falkland Islands were fired by the pre-dreadnought *Canopus*.